

BOOK REVIEW

MINE YOUR LANGUAGE: INFLUENCE, ENGAGE, PREDICT, by Abhishek Borah. India: Penguin Random House, March 2024, 448 pages. ISBN-13: 978-0-143-46162-3. Paperback.

In "Mine Your Language" (MYL), Abhishek Borah reveals a fascinating fact: the popular Bryan Adams song "Summer of 69" isn't about nostalgia for the year 1969, but rather refers to a sexual position (Gonzalez-Cavazos et al., 2023). This unexpected twist grabs the reader's attention and sets the tone for the entire book. Borah uncovers surprising insights about language and its powerful role in marketing and decision-making, demonstrating how words and phrases can influence our perceptions and actions in ways we might never have imagined.

Borah, an Associate Professor of Marketing at INSEAD, leverages his expertise in text mining and linguistics to offer a deep dive into how language shapes consumer behavior and business strategies. His background, which includes a PhD from the University of Southern California and positions at McKinsey and Company, adds a layer of credibility to his findings.

The book is structured into six sections and 22 chapters, each brimming with interesting anecdotes and practical applications. One of the most compelling chapters is "Improv on Social Media," where Borah uses the Luiz Suarez's biting incident of 2014 football World Cup as a case study. He illustrates how improvised marketing interventions (IMI) on social media can capture consumer attention. As Suarez bit an Italian player in middle of a match, brands like Snickers capitalized this incident on twitter by tagging Suarez and saying, "Next time you're hungry just grab a Snickers". Other brands also quickly adapted their messages to the dramatic turn of events, showing the importance of agility in marketing communication.

In another intriguing chapter, "Being Concrete in Language," Borah delves into the psychological impact of language on consumers. He describes an experiment where simply changing the wording of a message significantly influenced consumer perceptions. For instance, describing a beef product as "75% lean" was more appealing than "25% fat," even though both statements convey the same information (Levin & Gaeth, 1988). This chapter underscores the importance of word choice in marketing and how subtle shifts can lead to significant changes in consumer behavior.

Borah also covers the technical aspects of text mining in the chapter "How to become Sherlock Holmes Online". He breaks down complex methods and tools used to analyze textual data, making them accessible even to those new to the field. By providing practical examples, he ensures readers understand how these techniques can be applied in real-world scenarios. One example involves analyzing customer reviews to identify common pain

points, allowing businesses to address issues proactively (Kusawat & Teerakapibal, 2021).

In "Can Noise be Information?" Borah explores the concept of noise in financial markets. He explains how the seemingly chaotic environment of trading pits, filled with shouting and hand signals, actually conveys valuable information about market sentiment (Coval & Shumway, 2001). This insight challenges the conventional view that noise is merely a distraction, highlighting how even seemingly irrelevant data can hold significant value.

Another highlight is "A Crash Course on Charisma," where Borah discusses the role of language in brand management. He emphasizes the need for consistency and authenticity in brand messaging (D'Arco et al., 2024). Through the story of a successful rebranding effort, he illustrates how a well-crafted narrative can resonate with the target audience and strengthen brand loyalty. This chapter offers practical advice for brand managers looking to create compelling stories that connect with consumers.

The final section of the book looks ahead to future trends in language analysis. In "The Unexpected Side of Vagueness," Borah discusses the strategic use of ambiguity in communication, showing how it can sometimes be advantageous to leave things open to interpretation. He ends the book by providing a thought-provoking analysis of the opportunities and challenges of large language models and the ethical considerations of using generative AI to analyze consumer data.

One of the strengths of MYL is Borah's ability to simplify complex concepts without losing their essence. The book is research paper-centric but remains accessible to a broad audience. Each chapter is structured with a memoir, an in-depth study, and practical applications, ensuring that the material is both informative and relatable. For those interested only in implications and conclusions, the relevant chapters and research notes in the appendix provide a quick reference.

Despite its many strengths, the book sometimes assumes a level of familiarity with technical terms that may not be common among all readers. This could be a barrier for those new to the field of text mining and quantitative marketing. However, Borah's clear writing style and structured approach make these concepts more digestible. In summary, MYL caters to an audience of three key personas - casual readers grabbing a paperback or Kindle version for a long flight, early-career academics designing a marketing analytics seminar course, and brand managers looking to grasp social media marketing nuances.

Overall, MYL is a highly technical and analytical work that is surprisingly easy to read. Borah's blend of academic rigor and practical insights makes the book thought-provoking and rewarding. It stands out in the field of marketing literature for its depth of analysis and practical relevance. Compared to peer books, Borah's work offers a unique perspective on the intersection of language and business, making it a valuable resource for both scholars and practitioners. Borah adopts a format that brings to mind influential works like "Freakonomics" (FKS) by Levitt and Dubner and "Weapons of Math Destruction" (WMD) by Cathy O'Neil. MYL blends the engaging storytelling of FKS with the cautionary analysis of WMD, making complex ideas accessible and actionable.

Reading this book was not just an academic exercise but a journey into the nuances of language that shape our everyday interactions and business decisions. Whether you are a marketing scholar, a business professional, or simply someone interested in the power of words, MYL offers a wealth of knowledge and insights that are both enlightening and actionable.

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